

Four players, two fixed partnerships (you and the player opposite are partners). One team wins the bidding and commits to a *contract*: a trump suit (or no trumps) and a number of tricks. Make it and your team scores the bid's value; fail and that value is deducted. First team to 500 wins outright.

The pack

43 cards: red suits (♥ ♦) run 4 up to Ace, black suits (♠ ♣) run 5 up to Ace, plus one Joker.

The deal

10 cards to each player, 3 face-down to the middle as the **kitty** — the winning bidder picks these up before discarding back down to ten.

Ending the game

First team to reach **500** wins. A team falling to **-500** or worse loses immediately — "out the back door" — even mid-hand.

Bid Values

Every bid must beat the one before it. Same trick count, suits rank low to high left to right; Misère only over a seven (worth 250 — beats 8♠ but not 8♣).

Tricks	♠	♣	♦	♥	No Trumps
Six	40	60	80	100	120
Seven	140	160	180	200	220
Misère	250				
Eight	240	260	280	300	320
Nine	340	360	380	400	420
Ten	440	460	480	500	520

Slam: winning all ten tricks always scores at least 250, even on a cheaper bid. **Failed contract:** the bid's value is deducted (score can go negative). The other team scores 10 per trick they win regardless — except against Misère, where they score nothing.

Trumps, Bowers & the Joker

In a suit contract the top three trumps outrank everything else, highest first — shown here for a **Spades** contract:



The left bower belongs to the trump suit for following and winning, not the suit printed on it — pairs are ♠ ↔ ♣ and ♦ ↔ ♥. In No Trumps and Misère the Joker is the only trump; leading it means nominating a suit (one not yet led this hand) for the others to follow.

Special Contracts

Two rules worth a callout — both change how the hand is scored.

Misère

A contract to lose *every* trick, no trumps. The bidder's partner sits out (three-card tricks); the contract fails the instant the bidder wins a trick.

Bid Misère → lose all 10 tricks = **+250**

Open Misère (optional)

A bolder Misère worth 500: the same lose-every-trick contract, but the bidder's hand is laid face-up on the table for everyone to see for the whole hand. Play it as an extra rung above ordinary Misère if your table wants the higher-stakes version.

Bid Open Misère → win one trick = **-500**

Playing the Hand

- The contract winner leads first; play moves clockwise. Follow suit if you can — otherwise play anything, trump in or throw off a loser.
- The highest trump played wins the trick, or the highest card of the suit led if no trumps were played. The winner leads next.
- Holding only the left bower of the suit led does **not** force you to play it — it's a trump, not that suit, for this purpose.
- In Misère, if you can't follow suit and hold the (un-nominated) Joker, you must play it.

House-rule fill-ins — Target score: _____ Playing Open Misère? _____

This summary follows the Australian four-handed game as described by John McLeod at pagat.com/euchre/500.html. For the definitive treatment and every regional variation, see that page.

Hand	Contract	Team 1	Team 2
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
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16			
17			
18			
19			
20			
21			
22			

Write each hand's running total (not just the points added) so a big swing — or the ±500 finish — is easy to spot. "Contract" column: note the bid and who won it, e.g. "7♥ N" or "Misère S".